WORKSHOP · IIT GANDHINAGAR FDE COHORT

Think like a Forward Deployed Engineer

Start with why, not how.

Nikhel Bansal · Senior Forward Deployed Engineer

WHO I AM

Fourteen years in the field

14 years

Enterprise automation, integration platforms and agentic AI

Sr. FDE

At a product company, working side by side with enterprise customers

ProductTank

Part of the ProductTank Chandigarh community

“The projects that went wrong almost never failed on technology.”

WHAT YOU WILL LEAVE WITH

Three things for Monday

1

A mindset

Start with why and who, not with how

2

A framework

Why, Who, What, How, So what

3

A canvas

One page you can reuse on your next project

ICEBREAKER · POLL 1

In a typical week, an FDE spends most time on…

- **A** Writing code
- **B** Customer conversations
- **C** Debugging and integrations
- **D** Documentation
- **E** Internal syncs and escalations
- **F** Commercial and scoping talks

ICEBREAKER · CHAT STORM

Type one thing an FDE does between 9 and 6

Type it, but do not send yet. We will all press enter on 3, 2, 1.

Be specific: a task, a meeting or a conversation.

ICEBREAKER · THE REVEAL

What my week actually looked like

Activity	Share of my week
Writing code	[__%]
Customer conversations	[__%]
Debugging and integrations	[__%]
Documentation	[__%]
Internal syncs and escalations	[__%]
Commercial and scoping talks	[__%]

[Replace the blanks with your real, anonymized week. Then compare with the poll result.]

HOOK · FIRST MEETING WITH A CUSTOMER

“We want a chatbot for our support team.”

What is your first question?

HOOK · WHAT DID YOU ASK?

Most first questions are about how

How questions

- Which LLM should we use?
- What API does the ticketing tool have?
- RAG or fine-tuning?

Why and who questions

- Why a chatbot, and why now?
- Who asked for it, and who is worried?
- What does success look like in six months?

Same engineers, different order of questions.

THE ROLE

Three people, one customer problem

Product engineer

Builds one product for many customers

Success: the product is adopted

Sits with the team, far from the customer

Consultant

Advises one customer, usually on a slide deck

Success: the advice is accepted

Leaves before it has to work

Forward deployed engineer

Builds for one customer, inside their walls

Success: the customer outcome, and a product that learns

Stays until it works

An FDE is judged on the outcome, not the code.

THE ROLE

An FDE wears four hats

Engineer

Builds and debugs in the customer's real environment

Diplomat

Navigates people, politics and trust

Commercial owner

Represents your company: scope, pricing, expansion

Feedback loop

Carries what you learn back to the product team

THE ROLE · POLL 2

Which hat is this?

1 · Tell the CTO their data is unusable

2 · Flag a pricing gap to product

3 · Debug a failing integration at 11 pm

4 · Explain a new role to the support team

5 · Scope phase two after a pilot

6 · Write up the top three feature requests

7 · Get a blocker to approve data access

8 · Build the proof of concept

Pick: Engineer, Diplomat, Commercial or Feedback. Most tasks need two hats at once.

THE FRAMEWORK

Why, Who, What, How, So what

1

Why

Why this problem, and why now

2

Who

Stakeholders, goals and fears

3

What

Requirements and success metrics

4

How

The solution under real constraints

5

So what

KPIs, outcomes and next steps

Use it across the whole engagement: discover, design, deploy, adopt, expand.

Do not start with how.

LENS 1 OF 5

Why: this problem, and now

Ask yourself

- What is the pain, in the customer's words?
- Why now? What changed?
- What happens if nothing changes?

Common trap

Accepting the stated solution as the problem

You walk away with: a one-sentence problem statement

LENS 2 OF 5

Who: goals, fears, influence

Ask yourself

- Who feels the pain, who pays, who decides?
- What does each person want, and fear?
- Who could block this?

Common trap

Treating whoever briefed you as the only stakeholder

You walk away with: a stakeholder map with a goal and a fear per person

LENS 3 OF 5

What: requirements and metrics

Ask yourself

- What must be true for this to be a success?
- Which requirements are stated, and which are real?
- Which metric proves it?

Common trap

Requirements that no one can measure

You walk away with: requirements and 2 to 3 success metrics, agreed with stakeholders

LENS 4 OF 5

How: the smallest solution that works

Ask yourself

- What is the smallest solution that moves the metric?
- Which constraints are real: data, access, security, people?
- What will we deliberately not build?

Common trap

Building the impressive version first

You walk away with: a phased solution, mapped to each requirement

LENS 5 OF 5

So what: outcomes and next steps

Ask yourself

- How does each part of the solution move a KPI?
- What would we show the sponsor in 90 days?
- What comes next, and what do we tell the product team?

Common trap

A demo with no outcome

You walk away with: a KPI map and a next-step conversation

WORKED EXAMPLE · ILLUSTRATIVE

The chatbot ask, through five lenses

Lens	What we find
Why	Ticket volume is outgrowing the team; leadership wants cost per ticket down
Who	CFO: lower cost. Support head: fears cuts. IT: has not approved data access
What	Success is cost per ticket and first response time, not “a chatbot”
How	Start with three ticket types, read-only access and a human handoff
So what	Dashboard on both KPIs; phase two adds queues; integration gaps go to product

BREAKOUTS · 32 MINUTES

Your turn: a real customer case

How it works

- Groups of 4 to 5 in breakout rooms
- Four rounds, each with new context
- Capture your thinking on the shared canvas

Pick roles

- Scribe: writes on the canvas
- Timekeeper: keeps each round on time
- Reporter: shares with the room

Round 1: Why and Who · Round 2: What · Round 3: How · Round 4: So what

ROUND 1 OF 4 · 7 MINUTES · 0:40

Why and Who

Your task

- State the problem in one sentence: why does it matter, why now?
- Map every stakeholder: goal, fear, influence
- Who is your champion, and who could block you?
- You are scored on the questions you ask, not the answers you give

Case card

A European manufacturing company. Its customer service team answers orders and queries by email, across several regions.

“We want an email agent that gives us a 40% productivity gain.”

Ask me for more context in chat.

ROUND 2 OF 4 · 5 MINUTES · 0:47

What

Your task

- Turn the problem into 3 to 5 requirements
- Pick 2 or 3 success metrics and how you would measure them
- Which stated requirement conflicts with the real metric?

New context

- Today a first reply takes about 30 minutes, often one line
- The sponsor wants a draft ready in under 2 minutes, and a person reviews and sends
- The 40% productivity figure was agreed before the build
- No revenue goal is set yet, though more orders are hoped for

ROUND 3 OF 4 · 5 MINUTES · 0:52

How

Your task

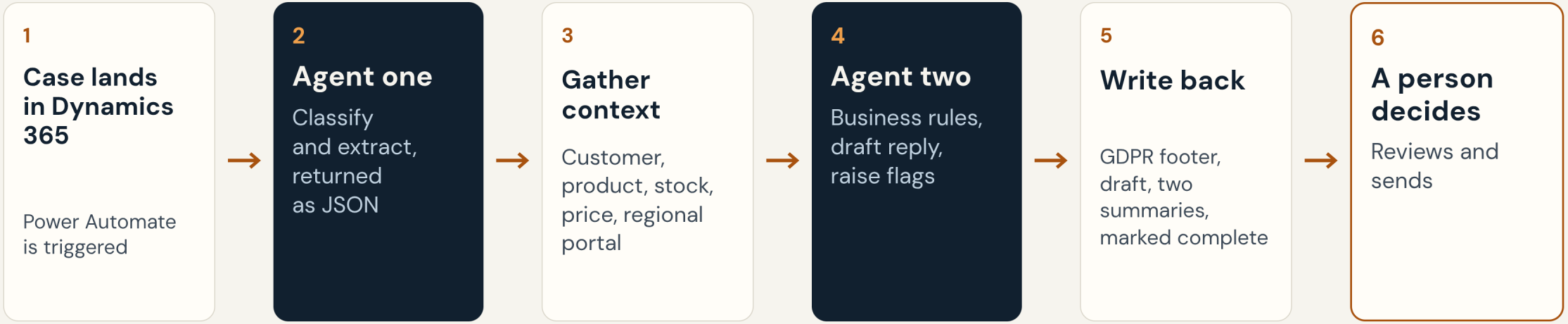
- Design the smallest solution that moves the metric
- Adapt it to the new constraint: what changes?
- What will you deliberately not build in phase one?

New constraints

- The service team refuses Copilot: “we live and die inside Dynamics 365”
- AI-written emails must carry a GDPR disclaimer
- Each region has its own ordering portal
- Product data is patchy, and prices are stored as text
- Emails are free text, often forwarded internally, some from new customers

REFERENCE SOLUTION · WHAT WE ACTUALLY BUILT

Fixed steps in the workflow, judgment in the agents



Dark boxes are AI agents on Foundry. Light boxes are fixed Power Automate steps.

Predictable work in the workflow. Judgment in the agent.

Legal text is never left to a model to remember.

Modular by region, so a new market is a small change.

ROUND 4 OF 4 · 6 MINUTES · 1:00

So what

Your task

- Map each part of the solution to a KPI
- Which outcome would you show the sponsor first?
- What is phase two, and what feedback do you carry back to product?

Outcome so far

- Phase one is live: drafts now take about 1.5 minutes, against a target of under 2 and a start of 30
- Phase two, order creation flagged “created by agent”, is in testing
- Weak spot: one Microsoft component was not good at drafting emails, so an alternative is being sought
- Almost blocked: other teams resisted, and the champion took the case straight to the CEO

BREAKOUTS · DEBRIEF

What did the framework change?

Where did your first instinct jump to how?

Which stakeholder changed your design?

Which metric did you almost miss?

BEYOND THE BUILD · COMMERCIAL HAT

Expansion starts with outcomes

Prove it first

Expansion follows a KPI the customer already trusts

Listen for next

Every constraint you hit may be a phase two

Bring your team

Loop in the account owner before pricing comes up

[Add your story: an anonymized expansion you led]

BEYOND THE BUILD · DIPLOMAT HAT

Politics is part of the engineering

Map before you build

Every stakeholder has a goal and a fear

Give the champion a win

Early, visible progress protects the project

Bring blockers in early

A consulted blocker often becomes a sponsor

[Add your story: a stakeholder who changed from blocker to sponsor]

BEYOND THE BUILD · FEEDBACK LOOP

Carry what you learn back

Capture it

Log gaps, workarounds and requests with the customer's context

Package it

Problem, impact and how many customers it touches

Close the loop

Tell the customer what happened to their request

"The customer wants X" is a request. "This blocks three customers from Y" is feedback.

CLOSE · 5 MINUTES

Your one-page FDE canvas

Why

The problem in one sentence

Who

Stakeholders, with a goal and a fear each

What

Requirements and 2 to 3 metrics

How

Smallest solution, and real constraints

So what

KPIs, next step, feedback to product

Your task

Pick a problem from your own work or studies

CLOSE · ONE LINE IN THE CHAT

Finish this sentence

“Before I think about how, I will first ask…”

Thank you. [Add your LinkedIn or email for follow-up questions]